

EUROPE'S BUDGET

Simplifying rules for European farmers and rural communities in the CAP 2028-2034

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Simpler rules and streamlined administrative obligations are key for fostering favourable business environments for the agri-food sector. When rules are easy to understand and apply, farmers can focus on their primary activities, while public authorities can work more efficiently spending less time on complex legal interpretations, offering faster and more reliable services to farmers.

Simplifying rules and procedures in the Common Agricultural Policy (CAP)

Significant simplification of the way the Common Agricultural Policy rules work was carried out in 2024 and 2025 for the current CAP 2023-2027. **Simpler fund management and delivery mechanisms are part of the proposed CAP 2028-2034**, bringing further improvements for farmers, national administrations, and other beneficiaries, including a single set of rules to apply as opposed to the current CAP.

As of 2028, the CAP funding framework will be delivered through National and Regional Partnership Plans (NRP Plans). This will result in a better use of synergies and complementarities across various funding instruments to address agriculture and rural areas' needs.

See factsheet [‘Unlocking synergies integrating EU funding for farming and rural communities’](#).



1. Benefits to farmers: streamlined rules for accessing financial support and reducing administrative burden

1.1. Simpler and more flexible funding application process in the CAP 2028-2034

A significant simplification change introduced in the CAP 2028-2034 is to **base income support for farmers on payments per eligible hectare and lump-sums, instead of the system of 'entitlements' linked to land**. This will allow to target funds to farmers having income needs and removing administrative burden for both farmers and national administrations.

For historical reasons, the previous **system of 'entitlements' linked to land** is used in several Member States to claim income support aid for farmers. This results in complex rules for transfers and management of a reserve for the allocation of new entitlements. Sometimes, farmers need external help to manage and transfer those entitlements. National administrations also have to manage and distribute the entitlements for young farmers and new entrants into farming via the reserve.

1.2. Simplifying support schemes and conditions for farmers: optimising time and administrative tasks

Supporting sustainable farming:
a better balance between incentives
and rules

'Farm stewardship'

This new system retains the Statutory Management Requirements (SMRs), which are existing obligations stemming from EU legislation outside of the CAP, while removing rigidities caused by the current EU's Good Agricultural and Environmental Conditions (GAECs). In the proposed CAP 2028-2034 the GAECs are replaced with 'protective practices' that give Member States greater leeway in guiding farmers in protecting natural resources. This not only allows practices to be more targeted to the specificities of

farming in the Member States but also helps them better align these practices with SMR obligations and national rules that pursue the same goals.

Agri-environmental and climate actions

The new **agri-environmental and climate actions** will merge the current eco-schemes and agroenvironment-climate commitments. Member States will be able to design a more consistent and streamlined choice of schemes for environment, climate and animal health and welfare, making it easier for farmers to select and apply for.

National rules equivalent to protective practices

Member States can set **equivalent rules** when delivering agri-environmental interventions such as maintenance of organic farming, extensification of livestock production and other voluntary management commitments, meaning that actions taken by farmers in these schemes are recognised as being in compliance with protective practices. For farmers, this avoids having to comply with similar, yet not the same, rules. It also makes it easier to combine different types of support, recognising farmers' efforts to farm in a more environmentally friendly way.

1.3 Easier access to financial resources improves farmers' liquidity

All Member States will have to offer smaller farmers the option of a simplified form of payment (up to EUR 3,000) that will minimise the administrative burden related to application, as well as controls. Many small farmers in the EU could use this option, depending on the level of payment set by Member States. Greater adoption of this intervention will help lowering the workload of national administrations related to collecting and processing CAP aid applications, thanks to fewer administrative checks and the lower complexity involved in these payments.

The new transition payment. It aims to encourage farmers to modernise the farms, endorsing more resilient and sustainable production systems (i.e. organic, low-input farming, agroecological systems, and extensive grazing livestock). Such support (up to EUR 200,000/farm), granted on a transition action plan prepared by the farmer, can cover all capital and management costs. These can include for example machinery, change of land practices and advice related to change.

Investments support

When farmers want to plan investments like introducing hedges, buying equipment or building farm infrastructure they can benefit from financial assistance provided through the simplified cost option. This method uses standard costs or flat rates related to the investment type and scale, eliminating the need to document each specific expense. This reduces administrative workload, the need for and cost of external expertise, and accelerates the application process. It also reduces the need for controls on low-risk investments.

1.4 Digital solutions to support farmers' decision-making and ease reporting

The **European Land Monitoring System** (ELMS) will allow farmers to better exploit and combine their land use data while keeping full control over it. Several Member States are already developing such projects, and the Commission will foster knowledge exchange between Member States.

Currently, 21% of farmers* signal duplicate reporting to authorities related to the CAP rules. This brings the figure to 49% where non-CAP origin is also included. By using **interoperable information systems** that work together and share information under farmers' control, public authorities can reuse data reducing the submissions from farmers. Under the CAP 2028-2034, Member States will be required to appoint a dedicated Data Governance Authority to coordinate this work, designing a roadmap to make reality the 'collect only once' principle. Together with less paperwork, this will mean fewer errors in complying with requirements and faster access to support.

[* Based on the 2024 survey of farmers](#)





1.5 A more proportionate approach to obligations and controls

The basic elements of the current administration and control system will be kept in the CAP 2028-2034 but simplified and streamlined, notably for controls related to other EU laws (SMRs). Member States will continue to be responsible for their effective and efficient design, building on the long-standing experience of the paying agencies in applying internationally recognised standards of internal control.

Small farms

As mentioned above, while small farms manage only a relatively modest share of the total agricultural area, they represent a large majority of CAP beneficiaries. They also typically rely only on family labour and have less capacity to absorb compliance costs. Applying the system of environmental obligations on these farms would generate significant cost and administrative burden compared to a limited environmental benefit. Building on the approach of the 2025 simplification of the CAP, such smaller farmers, when opting for payments for smaller farmers will be exempted from the mandatory system of protective practices (Farm Stewardship).

Moreover, all farms below 10 hectares, would be exempted from the controls and penalties relating to Farm Stewardship, thus avoiding the administrative costs of managing a reduction system for these farmers.

Organic farmers

Organic farmers will continue to benefit from a presumption of compliance approach under the 'Farm Stewardship' as regards certain protective practices related to soil and water. Organic farming principles and practices already provide similar protection levels and are therefore considered as 'green by definition', but it could be that they are the same as those Member States will set under the 'Farm Stewardship'. The approach of proportionality will also apply to organic farmers to prevent that they would have to 'duplicate practices' of the 'Farm Stewardship' as well as eliminate the related paperwork to that aid.

On-farm controls

Under the 'Farm Stewardship' system, controls will be decided by Member States. They will have to design effective and efficient management and control systems taking better account of each countries' specific farming systems, specific CAP solutions and risks. Currently there is 1% minimum control rate for conditionality (1% of farmers applying conditionality have to be controlled in each country).

Prevention-first: making the most of satellite technology

Member States can continue to exploit the benefits of technologies such as satellite imagery, drones or geo-tagged photos in administering the CAP. These technologies minimise the need for on-the-spot checks and allow to carry them out remotely. The use of such technologies help farmers take corrective actions and avoid penalties.

‘Further exploiting the benefits of the Area Monitoring System’

Making use of technologies such as Area Monitoring System (AMS) allows for a preventive approach in the management of the claims. If the AMS (e.g. by a satellite-based imagery) identifies different agricultural activities than those announced by the farmer in the aid application, the farmer receives a notification inviting him/her to act. The farmer can either still carry out the activity expected (e.g. mowing), change the aid application to align it with the activity observed or withdraw it. Information received from Member States shows that farmers significantly use this possibility, leading to great reduction in the number of penalties finally applied by administrations. On top of improving the relationship between farmers and administrations, this also saves administrative costs, as on-farm visits and application of penalties are cost-intensive exercises.

Increased transparency: The ‘Single Gateway’ will be a new online portal facilitating access to information about funding opportunities across EU policies. The Gateway will provide a user-friendly way for potential beneficiaries to find, in a single place,

suitable forms of financial support. This can increase awareness and access to wider funding opportunities for projects such as training, environment and climate transition, digitalisation or energy production. The Gateway will also provide a public dashboard displaying data on beneficiaries, operations and performance to show what the EU budget delivers through NRP Plans, including the CAP.



2. Benefits to national administrations

Efficiency in financial management: Removing complex and constraining rules about ring-fencing, earmarking, annual decommitments, transfers between the current two CAP pillars introduces greater efficiencies in financial management for the next programming period 2028-2034. In addition, the possibility for Member States to make some payment applications ahead of realising the expenditure (for investment support notably) will alleviate pressure on national treasuries. By investing in interoperable information systems, Member State public authorities will see burden reduction related to data collection and validation. This will avoid discrepancies between different sources and provide access to more integrated datasets allowing for better policy analysis.

A unified framework within the National and Regional Partnership plans makes it easier to monitor the effectiveness of the EU funding, ensuring better accountability and transparency. This will be helped by a common methodology tracking EU budget expenditure towards climate mitigation, climate adaptation, environment and social objectives. Further streamlining will be created with the single report on performance to the European Parliament and the Council, that replaces current 32 programme-specific reporting requirements, including the current CAP Strategic Plans' annual performance report.

Simplified audit rules: Member States and Commission **audits** will focus on the achievement of outputs, milestones, targets, and systems audits. Assessment of the management and control systems and their effective functioning will be maintained in order to ensure delivery on the overall objectives of the plan rather than verifying the correctness of individual transactions and operations. The existing **single audit approach** will be further strengthened, to avoid the same objective being audited by multiple national or EU institutions, enhancing coordination and exchange between the Commission and the audit authorities.

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